

Pahankanuwa Sermon #15

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Yo ca vassasataṃ jīve, dussīlo asamāhito; Ekāhaṃ jīvitaṃ seyyo,
sīlavato jhāyino.*

From:

Verse 110 from the Sahassavagga (Chapter of Thousands) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

A complete transformation in a human being's life does not require a long time. Sometimes, even through a brief mental revolution occurring in a split second, a great transformation of life, a complete reshaping of one's lifestyle, can take place. In this way, for some, a mental revolution occurs upon witnessing some sort of miracle. Indeed, what is called a miracle is a wondrous event capable of causing a special mental revolution in the mind of an individual or a group. It is concerning a bhikkhu who, through such a wondrous event, turned a band of thieves into a virtuous group, that the Buddha preached this stanza which we have taken as our theme.

There was a bhikkhu named Koṇḍañña who came to the Buddha and was ordained. That bhikkhu, having obtained meditation subjects (*kammaṭṭhāna*) from the Buddha, went to a distant forest, meditated, and attained Arahatship. Having attained Arahatship, while traveling back to see the Buddha to inform Him of the truth he had realized, he stepped slightly off the path due to the fatigue of the journey, sat down on a flat rock near the path, and entered into jhana. That very same evening, a band of five hundred thieves who had plundered a village and were carrying their bundles of loot on their heads, came to that same flat rock to spend the night while traveling along that path. Those thieves saw this

bhikkhu. However, in the darkness, this seated bhikkhu appeared like a post. They thought, "This is a post." Thinking so, one thief placed his bundle of goods on top of the bhikkhu's head. Another thief leaned his bundle against the bhikkhu's body. Then, all of these people lay down around the bhikkhu and fell asleep.

Waking up at the break of dawn and searching for their respective bundles, they saw this bhikkhu, got frightened, and thinking "It's a demon!" they all started running. Seeing this bhikkhu still holding the bundle on his head, they got frightened, cried "It's a demon!" and started running. The bhikkhu called out to them, saying, "Lay devotees (*upāsakas*), do not be afraid; I am an ordained monk." Thus, due to this incident, a great mental revolution occurred within this group. They begged for forgiveness, saying, "Venerable sir, please forgive us; we thought you were a post." Then, the leader of that band of thieves, due to the sense of urgency (*saṃvega*) that arose, decided to ordain. He requested of the bhikkhu, "Please ordain me." Thereupon, the others in that band of thieves also decided, in accordance with the decision made by their leader, "We too must ordain." All five hundred of them requested ordination from the bhikkhu. The bhikkhu also ordained them. Now, ordaining five hundred people is a grand task. Having ordained them in that manner and trained them, this bhikkhu traveled to see the Buddha. At the same time, a nickname was attached to this bhikkhu: "Khāṇu Koṇḍañña". He was originally known by the name Koṇḍañña, and *khāṇu* means a post, due to this incident of the post. Because news spread about the fact that he was mistaken for a post, the nickname "Khāṇu Koṇḍañña" was attached to that bhikkhu. In this Dispensation (*Sāsana*), this bhikkhu is known by the name Khāṇu Koṇḍañña. This is because the name "Khāṇu Koṇḍañña" is used to distinguish him from the more famous bhikkhu, Aññā Koṇḍañña.

Then, after Venerable Khāṇu Koṇḍañña arrived, the Buddha asked, "Well, Koṇḍañña, how is it that you have also acquired a group of disciples?" Thereupon, that bhikkhu related the news. The Buddha inquired of that group, "Is this matter true, monks?" Then this group declared, "We have never seen such psychic power (*iddhi*) or wondrous miracle, or the majesty of psychic power in anyone else. Because of that, we felt like ordaining." It was at that moment that the Buddha uttered the stanza we mentioned earlier:

Yo ca vassasatam jīve, duppañño asamāhito;

Ekāhaṃ jīvitam seyyo, paññāvantassa jhāyino.

(Though one should live a hundred years, foolish and uncontrolled, yet better is a single day's life of one who is wise and meditative.)

The Buddha tells this group: "Your previous way of life—that foolish, sinful life devoid of wisdom—abandoning that and turning toward a good life of this nature, practicing jhana with wisdom, that is indeed what is valuable." This is the meaning expressed by this stanza. The Buddha declared that even if one lives a hundred years without wisdom and without concentration (*samādhi*), a single day of life spent practicing jhana with wisdom is far more valuable. It is mentioned that upon hearing this stanza and this discourse, all five hundred of them attained Arahatsip.

Now let us try to extract some points useful for our lives based on this stanza and this story. Here, through this stanza, the Buddha highlighted a comparison between spiritual values—that is, Dhammic values—and worldly values. Looking at worldly values, society considers it a great thing to live for a hundred years in whatever manner—even unrighteously—without thinking about wisdom, knowledge, jhana, or concentration (*samādhi*). They say of such a person, "He enjoyed a long life." However, rather than enjoying such a long life, the Buddha declares that a single day spent practicing wisdom and jhana in this Dispensation is far more valuable. Rather than living a hundred years without wisdom and concentration, if one lives for just a single day with wisdom, practicing jhana, that single day of life is far more valuable. The Buddha declared this because, generally, in the world, people often consider only the matter of their unrighteous livelihood, thinking that as long as one lives somehow or other, that is all that is necessary. But, faithful devotees, we must contemplate with wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*). Generally speaking, when we talk about this human life, the great and valuable privilege that comes naturally to a human being, along with humanity itself, is this human mind. The greatest work that can be done with this human mind is to develop the wisdom that helps end the suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra and realize Nibbāna, and to practice meditation and jhana which support that wisdom. This human existence is especially a human existence obtained during a time when a Buddha has arisen (*Buddhotpāda kāla*). A time when a Buddha has arisen means a period in which one gets to hear the Dhamma, has the opportunity to realize Nibbāna, and has the opportunity to end the suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra. In a human existence obtained during such a period, one must use the human mind—which is the greatest privilege we have received—in a way that develops this wisdom, and in a way that develops concentration (*samādhi*), jhana, and so forth. However, most people in the ordinary world spend their lives without any awareness of these things.

Now, we also get a good example from this story through the course of action taken by this band of thieves. In this story, we can actually consider that there is not just one miracle, but two. One miracle is the miracle concerning that bhikkhu—the miracle shown by being endowed with wisdom and jhana, as the Buddha described. That is, sitting in concentration (*samādhi*) all night like a post is one kind of miracle. But the next miracle is the miracle shown by this leader of the thieves. Now, when there is a group, a group of five hundred people, there are great problems in deciding on a course of action to take, in making a wise decision. Yet, what was the courageous decision made by this leader of the thieves? If there had been something like a vote on separating himself from this wrong livelihood (*micchā-ājīva*)—this wrong way of living—which he had carried on for a long time, and ordaining in the Dispensation, it would have been a massive, tangled mess. But this individual also possessed a strong aspiration (*chanda*). Now, when we call this a psychic power (*iddhi*), four factors that support the performance of psychic miracles are mentioned in the Dhamma: *chanda* (aspiration), *virīya* (effort), *citta* (mind/determination), and *vīmaṃsā* (investigation). *Chanda* means the desire or the will. *Virīya* means the effort applied in accordance with that desire. *Citta* means the strength of determination applied to complete that effort, to make it successful. Next, *vīmaṃsā* means the examining wisdom, the investigative intellect, which helps to do and succeed in all of these. It is by depending on these four that one is able to show miracles—psychic miracles and so on. Thus, *iddhipāda*—*iddhi* meaning success—are the four factors that lead to success. Now, within this leader of the thieves, there was a firm determination. Accordingly, having fulfilled the required conditions, that leader of the thieves first stepped forward and said, "I must ordain." Following that, the other followers also decided to change their way of life. We can consider that to be a miracle as well.

Now this Dispensation is known as the Buddha's Dispensation, a Dispensation of Compassion. Due to the Buddha's great wisdom and great compassion, this Dispensation is known as a Dispensation of Compassion. Why? Because among those who ordained and became Arahats in this Dispensation, there are great murderers, notorious thieves, and women who led various kinds of bad lives. Many such people are found in the history of this Dispensation. It is said that they ordained under the Buddha in this Dispensation, attained the noble state of Arahatsip, and were worshiped and revered even by devas and Brahmas. Therefore, especially the story of Angulimala can create great courage in someone who is leading a wrong way of life to reshape their path of life. Angulimala is such a person. Just like this story of the notorious thieves here, his story is very well known among many. That Angulimala was a person who had killed thousands of people and was famous as a terrifying murderer. After ordaining in this Buddha's

Dispensation and becoming an Arahant as Venerable Angulimala, many people—sometimes even the bhikkhus—were talking about it as a highly wondrous thing. At that moment, the Buddha arrived there and preached a stanza. It is a stanza of the kind that creates great courage in anyone to correct their way of life. That stanza is:

Yassa pāpaṃ kataṃ kammaṃ

Kusalena pithīyati

So imaṃ lokaṃ pabhāseti

Abbhā mutto va candimā

(He whose evil deed is covered by a wholesome deed, illuminates this world like the moon freed from a cloud.)

The Buddha declared this. Now, when looking at the moon on a full-moon day, the moon is very glorious, very beautiful. It is even more beautiful when the moon emerges from a dark cloud; it has a special splendor. In the same way, when those who have lived a wrong life, darkened in that manner, and spent a life of dark deeds, lean toward the bright side, it stands out to the world. It is very beautiful. Just as a bright white spot on a black velvet background stands out clearly, in the same way, when a person who has led a bad life turns toward the good side, it is a great example to the world. It becomes a good proof showing the power of this Dispensation—this Dispensation of Compassion—and the power of the Buddha's Dhamma. If a person who led a wrong life, like that leader of the thieves did, carries out a transformation of life with a firm determination, it is like a psychic miracle.

Thus, we can see from everyone, when we contemplate how various individuals ordained in this Dispensation according to the Buddha's Dhamma and attained noble states, we cannot dismiss anyone. In general society, we marginalize people, saying so-and-so has no education, or is an extremely poor, destitute person, or is a low-caste person, a low person; some people marginalize others in this way. But if we contemplate in the correct manner, saṃsāric intelligence cannot be measured by greatness or smallness, nor can it be measured by social differences of high and low, educated and uneducated, or rich and poor. Those whose saṃsāric intelligence has matured, whose wisdom is close to dawning, can sometimes be found among very young children—among seven-year-old children, not only among adults. Likewise, they can be among uneducated people, among many who are illiterate, and also among poor people of castes considered to be the lowest. In this way, they can be among the destitute, among the outcasts

(*caṇḍālas*). When contemplating in this manner, fortune lies hidden within all of us. In the Dhamma, it is described as being like a lamp burning inside a clay pot. Wisdom—the light of wisdom—is not visible to the world. It must be brought out in the proper manner. It does not emerge on its own. For this, one must make an effort oneself. There may be some good wholesome actions (*kusala kamma*) lying underneath. One must make an effort oneself to bring them out. Now, no matter how majestic or skilled a lion is, if the lion is sleeping, prey will not enter its mouth on its own—some effort must be made. In the same way, it is only for the energetic person, the effortful person, that the miracle of merit, the fortune, that lies hidden within themselves can be brought to light.

What we should identify as fortune in this Dispensation, or what we should call spiritual fortune, is the bringing to light of this supramundane Dhamma wisdom, jhana, and so forth. Attaining those noble supramundane states—Sotāpanna (Stream-entry), Sakadāgāmi (Once-return), Anāgāmi (Non-return), and Arahāt—is what we should consider as fortune in this Dispensation. Now, in this society, we see people working hard to bring about financial fortune. We hear about so many opportunities to bring about this fortune through loudspeakers in society. We also constantly see people who tire themselves out to bring about this financial fortune. But only a very few are interested in bringing about spiritual (Dhammic) fortune. Now, we can say that a good day for those who want to bring about spiritual fortune is the Poya day. Therefore, we can call it 'Poya-day fortune'. It is only a very few who are interested in bringing about this 'Poya-day fortune'. It is not like other fortunes. However, if some person thinks about Poya-day fortune and, on that day, takes interest in observing precepts, listening to sermons, and shaping their life by contemplating in accordance with the Dhamma, then the light of wisdom that lies hidden within them, as mentioned before, can be brought to light. They can develop the mental strength to change their lifestyle. In that manner, we must be keen to shape our lives righteously.

From this story, we can obtain a great example to shape our lives and bring about a mental revolution. Even if one does not go deep into the Dhamma—the Dhamma preached by the Buddha—when contemplating its basic points, one can develop a great sense of urgency (*saṃvega*) regarding this condition of saṃsāra. Now, animal beings do not have the capacity to develop such wisdom or jhana. How miserable is the life that animal beings live? Next, those who have fallen into the states of yakkhas, pretas (ghosts), and so forth—the suffering of the hells—the Buddha has described these. None of us has been given this human existence as an absolute freehold. This is an extremely valuable opportunity obtained through some merit performed in the past. If we degrade this, if we do not make use of this, we do not know where we will go next. Unless one attains a state like Sotāpanna and escapes from the four lower realms, no matter how

good, beautiful, luxurious, and showy a life one leads, if one is engaged in evil deeds, if one is inclined toward wrong livelihood (*micchā-ājīva*)—wrong ways of living as mentioned before—then due to the sins such people commit, they will ultimately go and be born in places like the worlds of yakkhas and pretas. Then, they will have to come to their relatives and trouble them. It is on that day that they will understand merit and demerit, wholesome and unwholesome. Some people adopt intellectualism and remain engaged in various arguments and debates. It is after they die and go to the next world that they will understand. It is by merit and demerit, wholesome and unwholesome, that the true wealth in the world is measured. It is the currency that does not change. Other coins and other notes may be valid here. But it is according to this law of nature (*dhammatā*) shown by the Buddha, in the form of merit and demerit, wholesome and unwholesome, that the high and low differences in one's saṃsāric life are measured. It is through this that one goes to high states or low states. Therefore, lay devotees who have understood this matter in advance must kindly look closely at their own lifestyles. Now, the *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla* (Eight Precepts with Livelihood as the Eighth) that we have observed here—here, wrong livelihood (*micchā-ājīva*) is shown as trading in weapons, breeding animals for meat, trading in meat, trading in intoxicants, and trading in poisons. If we look at these according to ordinary social conventions, they are things through which one can get rich very quickly. However, because one's mind becomes defiled due to these, the Buddha has declared that one should separate oneself from these livelihoods and shape a good way of life. Wise devotees must contemplate this.

Next, what is the specific wisdom spoken of in this stanza? This wisdom is described in the Dhamma as a gem. The Buddha declared, "*Paññā narānaṃ ratanaṃ*" (Wisdom is the gem of human beings). The gem that humans possess is this wisdom. Now, among gems, there is the diamond, the vajra-gem. It is an extremely powerful gem that can cut other gems. This wisdom is like that vajra-gem. Why? Because this wisdom is described as "*nibbedhikā paññā*"—penetrating wisdom. Wherever we look in the world, what appears to us are permanent things. It is this wisdom that helps us see the impermanent (*anicca*) nature of these supposedly permanent things. Everything appears as permanent, as a solid—due to the perception of compactness (*ghana-saññā*). Yet, these things are changing extremely rapidly. Because this change is not seen, people form a wrong understanding of them as permanent, and due to that very reason, they develop intense craving (*taṇhā*) toward them, turn to various crimes and evil deeds, and travel in this saṃsāra for a long time. Therefore, if one is to realize Nibbāna, the impermanent (*anicca*) nature of these things taken as permanent must be directly realized by oneself. This is not done through spells or charms, nor by inference, but is directly realized through this wisdom—the light of

wisdom. This is a penetrating light. This is a certain understanding arising within the mind itself. That understanding does not occur on its own. It is for this that jhana and meditation are helpful.

Now, what is done in that meditation as insight (*vipassanā*) which supports wisdom? In this world, one begins to look at the impermanence (*anicca*), the arising and passing away of everything. Now, in the method of establishing mindfulness known as the Four Establishments of Mindfulness (*Satipaṭṭhāna*), the arising and passing away of this body, then of feelings (*vedanā*), of the mind, and of thoughts (mental objects) that come to the mind are shown. These arise and then they pass away. For a person who constantly contemplates this arising and passing away, a person who constantly contemplates these with good mindfulness and clear comprehension, very deep understandings arise. They are not deluded by that externally visible permanent nature. Now, a person seeing a banana trunk might think that this is wood with a good, solid core. But a person who has a correct understanding of it knows that this is just a bunch of fibrous layers. In the same way, the perception of permanence (*nicca-saññā*) regarding everything or all things is shattered; it loosens.

If one constantly looks at the arising and passing away of everything—regarding this body, and also our postures, our coming and going, if one looks at the arising and passing away of all of these—it is mentioned in the Dhamma as "*samudaya-dhammānupassī vā, vaya-dhammānupassī vā, samudayavaya-dhammānupassī vā*" and so on. That means one dwells contemplating the nature of arising in this. Next, one dwells contemplating the nature of passing away in this. Next, one dwells contemplating both the nature of arising and passing away in this. It is by dwelling in this manner, by developing this meditation in this manner, that gradually the impermanent (*anicca*) nature of these things begins to be understood by oneself. Now, when sharpening a razor, one draws the razor upward, then downward, then rapidly upward and downward from both sides, and that is how one sharpens the razor well. In the same way, in developing this insight wisdom—at times one dwells looking at the nature of arising in this manner, next at the nature of passing away, and next at both the extremely rapid arising and passing away, sharpening and developing it so that one sees both of these combined in a subtle manner. It is by doing so that this becomes a penetrating wisdom. A person who has developed it in this manner does not wait until it passes away; even as they look, they see that whatever has arisen is of a nature to pass away. A prior understanding of the impermanent (*anicca*) nature of everything comes to them. This is what is called wisdom. It is only a person who sees in this manner who can let go of the five aggregates. At some point, by developing that wisdom and looking at the arising and passing away of the body, of feelings (*vedanā*), of the mind, and of thoughts that come to the mind, and

gradually developing that wisdom, one realizes the Four Noble Truths—namely, suffering (*dukkha*), its origin (*samudaya*), its cessation (*nirodha*), and the path (*maggā*). This entire existence is suffering (*dukkha*). The cause for it is craving (*taṇhā*). One understands that it is because of this underlying craving (*taṇhā*) that one takes this as permanent through the perception of permanence. Next, when this craving (*taṇhā*) is absent, the state where that thirst of craving is quenched, that extinguishment—that is indeed Nibbāna. And what supports this is the Noble Eightfold Path. One realizes it in this manner—that it is by following the Noble Eightfold Path, namely, right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*), right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*), right speech (*sammā-vācā*), right action (*sammā-kammanta*), right livelihood (*sammā-ājīva*), right effort (*sammā-vāyāma*), right mindfulness (*sammā-sati*), and right concentration (*sammā-samādhi*), that one is able to realize Nibbāna. Thus, the Buddha has described that wisdom as a light.

On one occasion, the Buddha declared four lights that exist in the world: the light of the moon, next the light of the sun, next the light of fire, and next the light of wisdom. The light of wisdom is considered supreme and foremost among all lights. Even in the things seen by moonlight, there are their shadows. The light of the sun—even in those, there are shadows. Those thought of as lamplight or electric light—it is through those that we think we see someone exactly—but actually, the true seeing occurs through wisdom, through a certain understanding that comes from within. What is seen through that is what can be taken as the truth. Sometimes, one cannot see properly even with those lights like the sun's light or the moon's light. So much for that wisdom.

The Buddha declared in the same way regarding jhana. jhana means one-pointedness of mind, making the mind concentrated. Generally, the mind mostly exists in a scattered state. There are five hindrances (*nīvaraṇa*) known as sensual desire (*kāmacchanda*), ill-will (*vyāpāda*), sloth and torpor (*thīna-middha*), restlessness and worry (*uddhacca-kukkucca*), and doubt (*vicikicchā*). The mind is disturbed either by sensual thoughts or by angry thoughts. The mind is inactive due to sensual thoughts, angry thoughts, or due to sleepiness and laziness. Or, due to restless states, worry, and so forth, or due to doubts and hesitation, the Buddha has declared the occasions when the concentrated state of the mind is suppressed.

To withdraw the mind from those hindrances, the Buddha even declared similes on one occasion. That disturbance of the mind by sensual thoughts—the simile the Buddha gave for that is dye. Suppose there is a vessel of water. If a yellow, red, or blue dye is mixed into this vessel of water, one's face is not seen properly; the true state is not seen. In the same way, if the mind is disturbed by sensual lust

and so forth, such a person does not see their own welfare, does not see the welfare of others, nor does he see the welfare of both. Next, in the same way, anger—the disturbance of the mind by ill-will. The Buddha describes that as like boiling water in a vessel, water boiling over a fire; a person cannot see their face properly in it. In the same way, when boiling with anger, the true state of things is not understood. Next, if the mind becomes inactive and loses its functionality due to sleepiness and laziness, such states are shown as being like a water vessel covered with moss; in a water vessel covered with moss, one's face is not seen properly. Next, if restless states and worry—or regret over what one has done or not done—come to the mind, in those states too, the true state of things is not seen. The simile shown for that is a vessel of water where the water is rippled by the wind—by a blowing wind—or shaken—if a vessel of water is shaken—due to that rippling water, the face is not seen properly. Next, the hesitation called doubt. That too is something that destroys the mind's capacity to see the true state of things. When the mind is disturbed by doubts and hesitation, it is shown as being like looking at one's face in a vessel of water muddied with clay.

According to the similes shown by the Buddha in this manner, we can understand the things that obstruct concentration. It is when those are removed that jhana and concentration (*samādhi*) arise. Therefore, devotees who actually try to develop their mental power must be interested in developing this wisdom and jhana in the manner declared by the Buddha. Poya day is the occasion to make a good start on these. That is why we called it "Poya-day fortune". One must try to bring about some reshaping of one's own life. If that is not done, sometimes one will have great regret at the final moment. Therefore, one must form a firm determination to walk on this path to Nibbāna. The practice that shapes the path of life which supports this is what the Buddha declared as the Noble Eightfold Path. That is actually not something that exists merely in books, but a practice that must be developed by oneself, within one's own heart.

Right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) means correct vision. Now, before going on any journey, one must develop some understanding of where one is going. Sometimes, what we call far-sightedness is the understanding regarding the place we are going—whether it is a place with thorns and bushes, or whether going on this road will bring welfare to oneself. It is in that manner that right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) has been introduced. One completely instills into one's mind an understanding of the Four Noble Truths to a certain extent, the entire plan of this Dispensation. Right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) introduces this entire saṃsāric existence as suffering (*dukkha*). This may not have been fully understood by oneself yet, but the target is here. When traveling on this path, one understands that this very five aggregates are of the nature of suffering—this is suffering (*dukkha*). Next, the cause for this is craving (*taṇhā*). The peace obtained

when this craving (*taṇhā*) is stilled at some point is Nibbāna. Next, what supports this is also this Noble Eightfold Path. This starts with right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*). Therefore, one must obtain a correct vision, a basic understanding of the Buddha's Dhamma message—regarding that plan. One must be able to experience that plan in daily life, through the incidents that happen to oneself. Suppose one's friend passed away, or some wealth was lost; on such occasions, one can think, 'Look, I have received a part of the suffering (*dukkha*) declared by the Buddha. So, it is regarding this that this suffering (*dukkha*) has arisen in me. The cause for this is the craving (*taṇhā*) within me. It is because of the craving (*taṇhā*) for this man, this woman, or these things, that this suffering (*dukkha*) arose in me.' Next, if I stilled this craving (*taṇhā*) in some way, even for this moment, by contemplating in accordance with the Dhamma—at that moment, a great peace comes to me. Now, one does not cry and lament over the death of one's neighbors, but when a friend, a relative, or a beloved person is lost, why does one grieve? We think we are crying for that person, but we are not crying for them. We are crying for ourselves who have lost that person. 'Here am I without so-and-so. I lived with so-and-so, and I am the person who is without them'—thus, one is crying about oneself. One does not understand this. Therefore, at some point, one must contemplate this with wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*), realizing that 'what lies underneath this is craving (*taṇhā*)—not because of that person's goodness, but because of the attachment toward that person'—and still it. For that, one must practice the Four Noble Truths to a certain extent in daily life. It is by doing so and gradually developing through meditation that one is ultimately able to attain the realization of the paths and fruits (*magga-phala*). Thus, right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) means correct vision.

If one has obtained such an understanding, next, the gradual transformation that occurs within that person is what is called right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*)—correct thoughts and aspirations. It is according to the view, or the philosophy of life, that one has adopted that thoughts and aspirations are shaped. Now, to a person who steals, the thought of stealing comes wherever he looks. To a person who kills, the thought of killing. In that manner, it is according to the view one has adopted that those thoughts arise. So, the Buddha declares that right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*) means correct thoughts and aspirations. Now, right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) means correct vision. A person who has developed correct vision regarding the Four Noble Truths in that manner, next takes interest in right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*), which is correct thoughts and aspirations. The Buddha shows these as the intention of renunciation (*nekkhamma-saṅkappa*), the intention of non-ill-will (*avyāpāda-saṅkappa*), and the intention of harmlessness (*avihiṃsā-saṅkappa*). The intention of

renunciation (*nekkhamma-saṅkappa*) means leaving this household life, or departing from these fivefold sensual pleasures, and one must constantly bring up this thought—that this is the true peace. Even if one cannot free oneself from them, when these thoughts arise constantly in daily life, whether upon seeing the Sangha, or when reading books, or when listening to the Dhamma, thinking 'How good it would be if I could lead such a life,' along with that, the intention develops. The intention of non-ill-will (*avyāpāda-saṅkappa*) means thoughts of loving-kindness (*mettā*). One develops thoughts of loving-kindness which suppress anger. The intention of harmlessness (*avihiṃsā-saṅkappa*) means developing compassionate thoughts to avoid harming. In this way, good thoughts and aspirations develop.

Next, the words used in accordance with these thoughts and aspirations must also be shaped. Regarding those words, it is through lying, slander, harsh speech, and foolish babble—it is through these that one defiles speech. This gift of speech we have received is a rare gift. How many people are mute and unable to speak due to their kamma? Then, we must think of this also as a power received due to merit. Therefore, by lying, slandering, harsh speech, and talking about useless stories that are of no benefit to either world—if we degrade this power of speech through these, we lose this privilege we have received. That is why the Buddha declared instead that we should use good words, such as truthful speech, gentle speech, speech that unites others, and speech in accordance with the Dhamma.

A person who shapes speech in that manner also takes interest in acting in accordance with those words. That acting means determining to abstain from wrong actions, namely, killing living beings, stealing, and sexual misconduct. This is known as right action (*sammā-kammanta*). Next, another step from that is not merely to live in that manner occasionally, but to contemplate one's job, one's livelihood, and to live more righteously. One tries to avoid those things we mentioned earlier—trading in weapons, breeding animals for meat, trading in meat, trading in poisons, and trading in intoxicants—and to live by a righteous livelihood. That is what is called right livelihood (*sammā-ājīva*).

In the effort made for this, a certain meditative power that arises within the mind, called right effort (*sammā-vāyāma*), appears on its own. That right effort (*sammā-vāyāma*) means the constant effort made to remove unwholesome states and increase wholesome states, by carefully contemplating the wholesome and unwholesome states arising in one's mind. One has to make and apply a certain strong effort, energy, to prevent unarisen unwholesome states from entering the mind—that is what is meant by unarisen unwholesome states waiting to stream in. That is called the effort—the exertion—to prevent unarisen unwholesome states from arising. Next, to abandon arisen unwholesome states—

if there are wrong unwholesome states within oneself, one must apply a similarly strong effort to remove them. Next, one must also apply a special effort to bring about unarisen wholesome states. One must make a great effort, contemplating and thinking, 'These good virtues are not yet within me, I must develop them.' Next, if there are good wholesome states within oneself, one must also make an effort to establish and increase them, without letting them be destroyed.

To show how valuable that effort is, the Buddha has used a series of terms for that effort: "**chandaṃ janeti, vāyamati, viriyaṃ ārabhati, cittaṃ paggaṇhāti, padahati**". "**Chandaṃ janeti**" means, as we said earlier—the word **chanda** here does not have the meaning it has in these times. It is a much deeper meaning. **Chanda** means the desire to bring about wholesome states, the will to do something, the desire. One generates that **chanda**. Next, having generated that **chanda**, "**vāyamati**"—one makes an endeavor for that. Next, one does not stop the endeavor after doing it for a little while. One turns it into energy (**viriya**) and carries on that effort more and more intensely. Next, when carrying on that energy, when various obstacles present themselves—without letting the mind hesitate in their face, "**cittaṃ paggaṇhāti**" means to bring out a strong willpower—one brings out a strength of determination. Next, the word "**padahati**" is used to mean that, ultimately, even with the sacrifice of one's life, one performs that task with a firm determination: "I must do this somehow."

If someone applies energy in this fourfold manner within the mind, having separated themselves from their wrong ways of living—let's say a person who drinks alcohol, a person who kills animals, a person who steals, a person who murders—this person, having separated himself at least on the Poya day as mentioned before, and thinking about "Poya-day fortune," contemplates this a little by himself. He thinks how to do this. He contemplates the benefits of doing this, and the dangers of those wrong ways. Contemplating not just about this life but in accordance with the Dhamma declared by the Buddha regarding the entire *samsāra*, and thinking about the benefits, he thinks: 'If I degrade the capacity to bring to light this wisdom and *jhana*—the greatest privilege I have received from this human existence—will I also not fall to the level of an animal? Will I not fall to the state of a *preta*, to the state of a *yakkha*?' Contemplating thus, he directs his mind to bring about a complete transformation in his lifestyle. Through the effort made in that manner to remove unwholesome states and raise wholesome states, without even knowing it, he becomes a practitioner of yoga (**yogāvacara**), a meditator. That person is a most valuable individual.

What is the next result of the effort made in that manner? Due to that effort, right mindfulness (**sammā-sati**), which is good attention, is established within oneself. Now, what is called the "Four Establishments of Mindfulness"

(*Satipaṭṭhāna*) is establishing mindfulness regarding this body—one's own body or others' bodies—regarding feelings (*vedanā*), regarding the mind, and regarding the things (mental objects) that come to the mind. It is the person who has established that mindfulness who next sees their arising, passing away, and so forth, and brings to light wisdom. Therefore, this right effort (*sammā-vāyāma*) leans toward these Four Establishments of Mindfulness.

Next, the person who develops that mindfulness is able to practice concentration (*samādhi*) on some wholesome object of meditation (*kammaṭṭhāna*) by retaining mindfulness for a long time, such as for five minutes, ten minutes, an hour, or two hours. Therefore, next, the devotee who wants to bring to light 'Poya-day fortune' must take interest in a meditation. For meditation, the Buddha has presented various meditation subjects (*kammaṭṭhāna*), meditation themes. The Buddha has highlighted meditation subjects that can be practiced in a simple manner in daily life, through which one can reap their benefits on a daily basis: the four meditation subjects declared by the Buddha for both laypersons and ordained monks—namely, recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*), loving-kindness (*mettā*), foulness (*asubha*), and recollection of death (*maraṇassati*). Now, recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*) means keeping the mind on the virtues of the Buddha. The virtues of the Buddha are like a great ocean—if one brings out even a single word from the text of the nine virtues and contemplates the Buddha constantly through the word 'Arahant', 'Arahant', 'Arahant', or 'Buddho', or 'Bhagavā', and constantly recalls the Buddha with faith (*saddhā*) associated with some word, at that moment, that scattered nature of the mind disappears. Actually, what is done through a meditation subject? Suppose we have scattered water, or water flowing here and there; if we build a dam, collect it, and make a reservoir, we can get work out of that water. In the same way, keeping this running mind on one wholesome object is what is called meditation. In that manner, one constantly brings out from the mind a single virtue of the Buddha, or a short phrase in loving-kindness meditation like 'May they be well—may all beings be well and happy.' No one else needs to be told. When the mind goes astray, running to sinful states, to unwholesome states, one brings it back here. Thus, for the person who is keen and tries to tame this mind with the rope of mindfulness, a great number of benefits are received in daily life. Through the benefits of loving-kindness meditation, suppressing that angry mind, one can obtain great peace. Next, the same applies to the meditation on foulness (*asubha*). One receives the power to free the mind from the defilements (*kilesas*) that oppress the mind. Next, the meditation on recollection of death (*maraṇassati*)—developing a sense of urgency (*saṃvega*) and wanting to end this suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra quickly, without postponing these, one is motivated to walk on the path of Dhamma diligently. For

the person who practices recollection of death, impermanence (*anicca*) is also understood in the same way.

In that manner, if some person takes interest in this meditation, then even if they do not have a miracle as great as that bhikkhu's in their daily life, they can experience for themselves the peace that can be obtained from within by practicing jhana, by practicing meditation. We must contemplate the lessons we can take for our lives from such a story—the lessons we can take for our lives even from this one short stanza of the Buddha, a stanza of four lines—and take interest in these. Now, these devotees have observed the *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla* on this valuable Poya day, and also, through this valuable Dhamma story, a valuable Dhamma story from which one can take an example, listened to several Dhamma points. At this moment, one must contemplate the transformation that has occurred within one's own mind.

It is with faith (*saddhā*) in the Triple Gem that you came to such a sacred place. Likewise, you sat down to listen to this Dhamma. The mind was brightened by that faith (*saddhā*). A certain brightness of the mind occurred. Next, in accordance with that faith (*saddhā*), a certain effort (*virīya*) must be applied to sit comfortably during this sermon, to lend an ear to it; one must apply a certain effort for that too. Faith (*saddhā*), next effort (*virīya*), next, being mindful in accordance with that effort—mindfulness (*sati*). One listens to this with good mindfulness and wisdom. Next, when listening to it for a long time, some concentration (*samādhi*) is established—contemplating in accordance with the Dhamma as recollection of the Dhamma (*Dhammānussati*), understanding the value of the Dhamma—recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*)—when the Buddha is mentioned, as recollection of the Buddha, in various ways, one even gets an opportunity to develop some concentration. It is with that concentrated mind that next, the specific deep understandings called wisdom (*paññā*) arise. Those penetrating deep understandings mentioned before arise. Contemplating in this manner, it is by developing the faculties (*indriya*) of faith (*saddhā*), effort (*virīya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) that one is able to realize Nibbāna at some point. One must be happy, contemplating that this opportunity supported the development of those faculties, those faculties shown in the Dispensation.

This life is passing away extremely rapidly. Sometimes, seventy or eighty years, which we think of as a long time, pass away without us even knowing it. Through that, ultimately, when contemplating as death approaches, what did one do in this life? An emptiness is seen in it at the end. Sometimes, having spent unrighteous lives, in a sinful way, lives spent in drunkenness, one gets to see a

series of painful scenes like a film on one's deathbed. Therefore, one must contemplate spending a life in accordance with the Dhamma before that. If one can contemplate calmly and be happy even for a single moment in daily life, such a person is the wise person, the fortunate person.

Therefore, contemplating with wise attention, now one must contemplate how we share this mass of merit—this mass of merit accumulated in one's mind at this moment through listening to the Dhamma. Actually, in this universe, there are those who rejoice in merit and try to escape from their miserable states through it. Likewise, there are also those in this universe who use that merit to make their future aspirations successful. Contemplating thus, now may the guardian deities of the Dispensation, including the deities who preside over this place, rejoice in this mass of merit accumulated by both of us through preaching the Dhamma and listening to the Dhamma! May they realize the noble and supreme Nibbāna through a Bodhi of their aspiration! Contemplating thus, one must share merit with the deities. Likewise, may one's deceased relatives, and whatever beings from Avīci hell up to the Akanitṭha heaven who desire merit, rejoice in this merit of preaching the Dhamma and listening to the Dhamma! Having rejoiced, may they be comforted by the noble and supreme Nibbāna through a Bodhi of their aspiration! Thus one must wish. Likewise, depending on this noble mass of merit accumulated so far through observing precepts, listening to the Dhamma, sharing merit, and so forth, may these devotees, in this very life, as quickly as possible, through the realization of the paths and fruits of Sotāpanna, Sakadāgāmi, Anāgāmi, and Arahāt, gain the strength and power to escape from that terrifying suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra and be comforted by the noble and supreme Nibbāna! Wishing thus, now recite the stanzas and transfer merit in this manner.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”